ultimately resulted in the legislative abolition of the practice. Despite its abolition, the narrative of temple prostitution continued to be advanced in order to strengthen the perception that the ‘Hindoo religion’ was so fundamentally debauched, corrupt and obsessed with sex that its places of worship were also sites of prostitution. This coupled with the caricature of the evil Brahmin, effectively painted a picture that women were being forced to become temple prostitutes to pander to the dictates of the ‘Brahminical religion’.

No wonder the debates in the British Parliament pejoratively used ‘priestcraft’[4] to refer to Brahmins and everything they subscribed to or were associated with, especially the Dharmashastras. This is corroborated by the view of Charles Grant, an evangelical-minded member of the British Parliament, on the Manusmriti,[5] which is as follows:

> Nothing is more plain, than that this whole fabric is the work of a crafty and imperious priesthood, who feigned a divine revelation and appointment, to invest their own order, in perpetuity, with the most absolute empire over the civil state of the Hindoos, as well as over their minds.

De Roover argues that the Christian framework within which the British policy of toleration towards Indic faith systems and practices was adopted did not leave such systems untouched. On the contrary, indigenous/Indic OET was restructured to fit into the Christian idea of ‘religion’, which was embraced, unfortunately, by Hindu ‘reform’ movements as well. This translated to a doctrinal and scriptural approach to ‘Hinduism’, that is, only those practices which could be traced to the sacred texts of Hinduism would be tolerated by the colonial State, while the rest would be treated as superstitious and immoral, warranting State interference. To support this, the coloniser drew from the Protestant/Lockean position that struck a distinction between ‘core’ religious practices that did not warrant State interference, and ‘false religion’ and civil/secular aspects of religious practices that permitted State intervention. Here are a few educative excerpts on the said issue from De Roover’s book:

> The framework underlying Locke’s theory clarifies why it was so important to know whether the ‘sacred laws of the Hindu religion’